

Capitol Hill Crawler

Design Addendum — Systems Built Since Story Bible V3

Purpose of this document: This addendum captures every mechanic, NPC, and system decided in planning conversations since the V3 Story Bible was written. It does not replace the Bible — it extends it. Treat the Bible as the original architecture and this document as the renovation notes. Where the two conflict, this document reflects the current, approved design.

Status: Planning complete for House, Senate, and Oval Office levels at the systems/framework level. Still pending: art direction notes (in progress in NotebookLM), finished map layouts (in hand, minor fixes pending), and placement of named NPCs onto those maps.

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1. Core Systems Added Since V3

1.1 The Rapport & Trait System

Every named vote-holding NPC (bloc leaders, not loners or decorative sprites) now has a short Rapport Phase before their trivia battle. The player is offered 2-3 dialogue choices (4-5 for bosses); each choice nudges a Rapport score up or down and logs a 'stance tag' to the player's permanent Voting Record.

Rapport modifies the difficulty of the battle that follows — NOT the facts required to win. High rapport = friendlier UI mode, hints shown, looser answer matching. Low rapport = harsher mode (more options, less forgiving matching, mumbled/obscured text where applicable).

NPC personality traits (e.g., pragmatic/idealistic, compromiser/firm, detail-oriented/big-picture) are drawn from a small trait pool and RANDOMIZED at the start of each new playthrough, for replay value. The same NPC may want a different answer next time you play.

There is no 'insincere' or hidden trap option in rapport dialogue. Guessing wrong on a trait simply fails to raise rapport — it never actively punishes or flags the player.

Resolved (Rapport Scale): Rapport runs 0-100 per NPC, starting at 50 (neutral) for every conversation. Matching the NPC's rolled trait moves it +15; mismatching moves it -15. Tiers: 0-33 Hostile, 34-66 Neutral, 67-100 Friendly — the same Friendly/Neutral/Hostile tiers used by the Difficulty Delta and multi-part answer systems (Sections 6.4-6.5). With 2-3 choices for standard NPCs, a conversation can swing $\pm 30-45$, enough to cross tiers but not guaranteed on one pick; bosses (4-5 choices) swing $\pm 60-75$, matching their higher stakes. Loners are unaffected, per Section 2.1.

1.2 The Voting Record

Every stance choice the player makes in a rapport conversation (not their citizenship-trivia answers, which are simply right or wrong) is logged permanently for that playthrough. Later NPCs can reference earlier stances. Inconsistency (telling one leader one thing and a later leader the opposite) makes subsequent battles harder — it never locks content outright or forces a restart.

1.3 Scouting & Intel

Two tiers of NPC readability:

- **Moderate NPCs** (near the center of the Polarization Scale): give a subtle in-conversation tell (a gesture, an aside line) hinting at their rolled traits. No side quest required.
- **Extreme NPCs:** give no tell at all. Their traits can only be learned via optional scouting side quests (staffers, interns, message boards, press conferences) that log intel to the player's Notebook.

Every leader can be engaged twice. A wrong first attempt does not lock them out — it triggers a second, slightly more revealing chance before they lock for the remainder of that playthrough.

1.4 The Notebook

A persistent tab/UI overlay (already present in the V3 Bible via the Archivist side quest) that logs citizenship-test Q&A pairs as the player collects them, plus scouted NPC intel. Central to two new systems below: the 128-question completion shortcut ending, and several Senate Hold quests.

2. The House Level

2.1 Vote Budget

218 votes are required to pass; all 435 House votes are represented across roughly 21-24 NPCs, so players are never required to court every leader — this creates real strategic choice about which coalitions to pursue.

NPC Type	Count	Votes Each	Subtotal
Major bloc leaders	3	~35-40	~115
Mid-tier bloc leaders	~11-12	~18-24	~250-260
Loners	~7-9	2-10 (scales with centrality)	~60-70

Loner vote value scales with proximity to the center of the Polarization Scale: near-center loners are worth more votes (8-10), far-extreme loners are worth fewer (2-4). This mirrors real coalition-building (moderates are the valuable 'gettable' votes) and keeps the hardest loner fights from feeling like a bad trade for a handful of votes.

Loners have no rapport dialogue tree — a quick greeting plus one trivia question at whatever UI mode their fixed coordinate dictates. However, the player's accumulated Voting Record still applies and can nudge a loner encounter slightly easier or harder.

2.2 Named NPCs — Confirmed in Bible

Name	Role	Coordinate	Votes
Rep. Sarah Sterling	Major leader, Bipartisan Solvers Coalition	51 (49 if player is Republican)	40
Rep. Marcus Vance	Extreme intra-party gatekeeper, Progressive Coalition	5	15

2.3 Named NPCs — New Roster (Names & Personalities Only, Placement Pending)

Majors (35-40 votes each)

Name	Caucus	Personality	Trait Pair
Rep. Diane Okafor	Loyalist West Caucus	Sharp, no-nonsense organizer; speaks in headcounts and vote math	pragmatic/idealistic
Rep. Tom Bracewell	Loyalist East Caucus	Folksy old-guard veteran; long stories, genuinely likes new members	compromiser/firm

Mid-Tier (18-24 votes each)

Name	Personality	Trait Pair
Rep. Priya Anand	Policy wonk, quotes statistics, impatient with vague answers	detail-oriented/big-picture
Rep. Hank Delgado	Ex-small-business owner; judges by 'would this work back home'	pragmatic/idealistic
Rep. Wren Castellano	Freshman-friendly mentor figure, actively rooting for the player	compromiser/firm
Rep. Gus Whitfield	Grumpy committee-room lifer; respects preparation, hates being rushed	detail-oriented/big-picture
Rep. Naomi Cho	Media-savvy; cares how the vote will look, asks about optics	pragmatic/idealistic
Rep. Earl Pruitt	Rural-district loyalist; suspicious of 'D.C. insiders,' warms slowly	firm/compromiser
Rep. Selena Marsh	Coalition-builder; name-drops other leaders she's convinced	compromiser/firm
Rep. Otis Reinholt	Budget hawk; only cost matters, everything else is noise	detail-oriented/big-picture
Rep. Ines Falkenrath	Idealistic first-termer; inspired by conviction, turned off by cynicism	idealistic/pragmatic
Rep. Cyrus Boone	Old committee-chairman energy; tests you before taking you seriously	firm/detail-oriented

Loners (value scales with centrality)

Name	Personality	Approx. Coordinate
Rep. Alma Judd	Quiet, decisive, votes fast once persuaded	Near-center
Rep. Dez Okonkwo	Friendly hallway chatter, easy to approach	Near-center
Rep. Fritz Callahan	Distracted, always eating lunch at his desk	Near-center
Rep. Robin Yates	Cautiously undecided, needs a nudge	Mid-distance
Rep. Marv Tillson	Skeptical, arms crossed, slow to warm	Mid-distance
Rep. Ada Boykin	True believer, hard sell unless you match her intensity	Far-extreme
Rep. Silas Kroft	Combative, treats every question like a gotcha	Far-extreme
Rep. Clem Osgood	Barely listens, recites talking points instead of answering	Far-extreme

2.4 Night/DC Alternates (Non-Major NPCs Only)

Four non-major NPCs can be found in a more relaxed DC location at night, with a small rapport bonus there versus their normal Capitol encounter. Their day-side encounter always remains available at default difficulty — the night spot is a bonus path, never a requirement.

NPC	Day Location	Night/DC Location
Rep. Wren Castellano	House chamber	Quiet café near the Mall, still 'mentoring' off-duty
Rep. Naomi Cho	House chamber	Evening press stand-up near the monuments
Rep. Dez Okonkwo	House hallway	Wandering the DC map, chatting with tourists
Rep. Fritz Callahan	House desk	Late-night diner near the monuments

2.5 Fail State / Safety Valve

If a player exhausts every reachable House NPC and still cannot reach 218 votes, the Backbench Reserve Pool becomes available — a small set of previously-unengaged backbench Representatives the Whip can bring in as a last resort. Their vote values are uneven/randomized per playthrough rather than a fixed even split, totaling roughly 40 votes across the pool. This is a distinct mechanic from the Senate's Rogue Senator Nodes (Section 3.4) and does not share any name, location, or vote logic with it. Because 435 total votes minus the 218 required already gives 217 votes of natural slack, this safety pool should rarely be needed in practice — it exists for genuinely unlucky or lockout-heavy runs, not as a normal part of play.

If the player still cannot reach 218 after exhausting the Backbench Reserve Pool, this is a true loss state: the bill becomes unpassable and a restart is required. This is the one deliberate exception to the game's general 'no forced restarts' philosophy.

2.6 The Committee Dungeon

Resolved: the Committee Room icon shown on the House map (Image 2) is an entrance point, not the literal battle space — stepping into it transitions the player into a separate, self-contained instance distinct from the maze layout pictured. That map image needs a small clarifying note during the art pass (see Section 8), not a redesign.

- **Trigger:** Becomes available once the player reaches 175 votes — the same gate as the Extremist Ambush (Section 6.1). It cannot be entered earlier.
- **Core Gameplay:** One large committee-markup room where the player must “convince” several NPCs through a mix of trivia questions (drawn from the shared active pool, per Section 6.2/Item 8) and small fetch-quest-style tasks. The player is locked in until they pass or fail the room as a whole — there's no partial exit.
- **Committee_Status Scaling:** Both room complexity (number of NPCs/tasks to clear) and trivia difficulty (UI mode harshness, per the Difficulty Delta table) scale with whether Committee_Status is Friendly or Hostile Markup, per the Extremist Ambush outcome.
- **Mandatory, but survivable either way:** Passing OR failing the Committee Dungeon still leaves a path to 218 votes — it's a strategic gamble on efficiency, not a hard gate.

Outcome	Votes Awarded	Result
Pass	+35 votes	Lands around 210/218 — needs exactly one more encounter to close it out
Fail	+15 votes	Lands around 190/218 — needs several harder encounters (Majors/Mid-tier/Loners) to close the larger remaining gap

This vote injection is flat and NPC-agnostic rather than tied to any specific bloc, since exactly how many Mid-tier/Loner NPCs are still unvisited at the 175-vote mark varies by playthrough.

3. The Senate Level

3.1 Vote Budget & Structure

10 Faction Leaders, 10 votes each, 100 votes total. 60 votes (Cloture) required to advance. Leaders are split into three engagement tiers by Polarization Coordinate:

Zone	Coordinate Range	Count	Mechanic
Moderate core	35-65	4	Direct rapport + battle, no Hold
Near-flank	25-34 and 66-75	4 (2 per side)	Hold (fetch-quest gate) required before battle
Extreme	<25 or >75	2 (1 per side)	Full rapport/trait-scouting, boss-tier

The Senate does not have a House-style forced Extremist Ambush event. The existing Filibuster Gauntlet (triggered automatically at 50 votes: 5 back-to-back multiple-choice questions, no pauses) already serves as the Senate's one forced, high-stakes set-piece. The 2 extreme leaders are optional desks the player may approach on their own timing — a player could theoretically hit the Gauntlet having never engaged either extreme.

3.2 Named NPCs — Confirmed in Bible

Sen. Eleanor Vance — Coordinate 55, triggers the Hold on the bill; her fetch quest (retrieve the 'Economic Impact Briefing' from the basement archive maze) is the template for the other three Hold leaders below.

3.3 Named NPCs — New Roster

Moderate Core (no Hold)

Name	Personality
Sen. Regina Alvarez	Dealmaker, genuinely enjoys negotiation as a craft
Sen. Walt Iverson	Calm institutionalist, quotes Senate precedent constantly
Sen. Bee Nakamura	Energetic newcomer to leadership, eager to prove she can close votes
Sen. Roland Fitch	Retiring soon, unusually candid because he has nothing left to lose

Near-Flank (Hold-Gated)

Name	Hold Type	Personality
Sen. Corinne Vasquez	'Favor Trade' — one extra citizenship question, framed as convincing a colleague on her behalf	Transactional, everything's a trade
Sen. Del Ashworth	Notebook progress gate — 64+ total entries already, OR 5 new entries collected after first speaking to him, whichever comes first	Old-school, believes you should 'know your civics' first
Sen. Priya Okafor-Lin	Fetch quest (missing briefcase/notes); bypassable via ITEM_SCHEDULING_FAVOR, 100 INF	Busy, impatient, respects anyone who's prepared enough to skip the runaround

Extreme (Rapport/Trait-Scouting, Boss-Tier)

Name	Side	Personality
Sen. Augustus “The Anchor” Kane	Far-right	Booming, theatrical, treats every conversation like a floor speech
Sen. Lucia Marchetti	Far-left	Intense, principled, zero patience for perceived half-measures

3.4 Overtime (Failed Filibuster Gauntlet)

If the player fails the Gauntlet, the Senate sets a Gridlock flag. Two paths now exist to break it:

- **Path A (grind):** Hunt down the 10 Rogue Senator Nodes across the hidden Cloakroom/Subway maps, solving open-ended challenges with zero hints.
- **Path B (skill):** Attempt to win over one of the 2 extreme Faction Leaders instead. Multiple-choice format escalates to a 12-option grid with multiple correct answers required — the player must score 75% correct to pass ('It is your own party, after all'). Open-ended format stays single-answer, since stacking multiple-correct onto free-text input is impractical on Chromebook or PC keyboards alike.

4. The Oval Office Level

4.1 Boss Encounter — Revised

Coin-flip determines Ally President (multiple-choice) or Opposition President (open-ended, timed, Levenshtein distance ≤ 2).

Ally President path: 20 multiple-choice questions asked; the moment the player reaches 12 correct, the encounter ends immediately in success. Every question that was never asked (because the threshold was hit early) earns a bonus of 100 points each. Example: reaching 12 correct on the 15th question leaves 5 unasked questions = 500 bonus points.

Resolved: The Opposition President path stays as originally designed — 10 open-ended questions, 30-second timer per question, Levenshtein ≤ 2 , need 6 correct. It does not get updated to match the Ally President's 20-question/12-correct/bonus-point structure.

4.2 The Veto Override

If the player falls short of the win threshold, the bill is vetoed rather than the game ending outright. This triggers a Veto Override sequence: the player returns to the already-explored House and Senate maps to gather a two-thirds majority (~290 House votes, ~67 Senate votes) instead of a simple majority, reusing all existing NPCs, maps, and the trivia engine — no new content required.

Resolved (question pool during Override): NPCs re-engaged during the Override draw only from questions the player previously answered incorrectly or never got asked, out of their original 64-question session pool — never questions already answered correctly. This turns the Override into a genuine second chance rather than a repeat of material the player has already proven they know. Fallback: in the rare case a player answered their entire original 64 correctly (leaving nothing wrong/unanswered to draw from), the Override falls back to drawing from the other, unused 64 questions of the full 128-question bank, so an NPC is never left with nothing to ask.

Any NPCs the player permanently locked out earlier (via the two-failed-attempts rule) get a one-time single-attempt reopening during the Override, framed narratively as 'one more shot to change minds.' This prevents a mathematically stranded player without adding a new system.

Failing the Veto Override is true game over — the bill fails outright and a restart is required.

4.3 The Notebook Completion Ending

If the player has logged all 128 citizenship Q&A pairs in their Notebook before reaching the Oval Office, they may walk the bill directly to the President's desk and have it signed without the citizenship-test boss battle at all — an earned shortcut ending for completionists.

4.4 Ghosts of Washington & Lincoln

The two hardest Notebook entries to obtain, designed as a two-stage secret rather than two independent easter eggs. These 2 questions are Ghost-exclusive — unobtainable via side quests or the Rotunda Shop — completing the full 96 (side-quest) + 30 (store-exclusive) + 2 (Ghost-exclusive) = 128 question accounting detailed in Section 6.3.

Ghost of George Washington — Washington Monument

Appears only during nighttime AND only once the player has 100+ of 128 Notebook entries. Formal, measured, faintly amused by modern politics. Rather than asking a direct question, he offers a riddle the player must independently verify:

“Twice I was asked to lead this country, and twice I said yes. A third time was offered to me, freely, with no law standing in the way — and that time, I said no. I walked back to my farm instead, because I believed no one man should hold this office forever, law or no law. It took over a century and a half before anyone wrote my choice into the Constitution itself. Tell me, young Representative — how many terms does the law now say a President may serve?”

Answer target: the 22nd Amendment / two-term limit. The player must already have logged this fact elsewhere on the map (a tourist, an NPC, or prior research) before speaking to him — he will not simply accept a guessed answer; showing up unprepared means leaving empty-handed.

Ghost of Abraham Lincoln — Lincoln Memorial

Appears only once the player is at 127/128 Notebook entries and standing at the threshold of the Oval Office, ready to enter. The West Wing prep NPC notices the near-complete Notebook and offers the player a choice to make one more stop before proceeding. Lincoln does not test knowledge (the player has already proven that 127 times over) — he tests resolve, via a narrative-only choice with no right or wrong answer:

“So. Why'd you come back?”

Player Choice	Lincoln's Response
“I couldn't leave the job half-finished.”	“I understand that better than most. I signed my name to plenty of things I wasn't sure I'd live to see finished. Finish it, then.”
“It mattered to me to get it right, not just get it done.”	“Careful with that one, son. I told myself the same thing... you're not fighting a war. You've got the time I didn't. Use it.”
“Honestly? I just wanted to see if I could.”	“Well, at least you're honest... you did. That counts for something.”

All three paths lead to the same closing line and Notebook entry (Emancipation Proclamation), completing the 128th and final entry.

4.5 Scoring Economy

Resolved: 10,000 points is the target for a perfect run. Full breakdown below.

Category	Points	Basis
Base Clear (bill signed)	2,000	Flat floor — every finisher gets this, regardless of path
Oval Office Accuracy Bonus	up to 800	100 pts × up to 8 unanswered questions (Ally President path, Section 4.1)

Category	Points	Basis
Full Notebook Completion	2,000	All 128/128 entries collected (ties to the Section 4.3 completionist ending)
Day/Night Speed Bonus	up to 2,000	Finishing within the fastest pacing tier (~2-3 in-game days, per Section 5)
INF Efficiency Bonus	up to 3,200	Leftover INF $\times$ 3, capped at 3,200 (realistic max $\approx$ 1,050 leftover INF after buying all 30 store-exclusive questions, per Section 4.6)
Total (perfect run)	10,000	

A 'perfect run' requires full completion (128/128 Notebook, meaning 750 INF spent on the store-exclusive pool), fast play, and Oval Office accuracy — every category's cap is built from numbers already established elsewhere in the doc rather than new mechanics. Base Clear alone (2,000) guarantees every finisher a real score. House/Senate performance feeds score only indirectly through INF earned there (Section 4.6) — there is no separate parallel point-track for those stages, so nothing double-counts.

4.6 The INF Economy

Resolved: Earn rates and Rotunda Shop pricing are calibrated so a thorough player can afford to purchase the entire 30-question store-exclusive pool (Section 6.3) in a single playthrough, in addition to other shop items — not an either/or choice.

UI Mode (Difficulty Delta)	INF per Correct Answer
3-option MC ($D \leq 5$, Friendly)	15
Open keyboard ($5 \leq D \leq 15$, Neutral)	25
12-option grid / mumbled ($D \geq 40$, Hostile)	40

A thorough player answering most of their ~64-question session pool correctly nets roughly 1,400-1,800 INF per playthrough.

Rotunda Shop Item	Cost
Store-exclusive Notebook question (flat price, $\times 30$ available)	25 INF
Cafeteria Coffee (minor buff)	30 INF
Talking Points Memo (rapport boost)	40 INF
Hearing Aid (reveals a trait tell)	60 INF
Super PAC Injection (bypasses 5 Rogue Senator Nodes)	250 INF

The math: all 30 store-exclusive questions cost $30 \times 25 = 750$ INF. Against a 1,400-1,800 INF playthrough budget, that leaves 650-1,050 INF free for buffs and the Super PAC Injection — a strong player can unlock the full 128-question bank AND still afford other purchases in the same run.

5. Day/Night Cycle

Purely mechanical in only two respects: (1) gating Washington's ghost, and (2) a speed bonus in final scoring. It has no other gameplay effect except allowing 4 specific non-major NPCs to be found at an easier, alternate DC location at night (see Section 2.4).

Clock advancement: each vote earned advances the in-game clock 10 minutes; each step taken advances it 5 minutes. A full day/night cycle is 1,440 minutes (24 hours).

Rough pacing estimate: a typical playthrough (150-250 House votes, up to 100 Senate votes, plus map traversal) accumulates roughly 4,000-6,000 minutes total, or about 3-4 in-game days — enough cycling for night to matter without becoming meaningless background noise. An efficient player might finish in 2-3 days; a player who grinds every loner and re-attempts locked NPCs might stretch to 5-6, creating a real, visible gap for the speed bonus.

6. Question Bank Update

The game now uses the 128-question U.S. Citizenship Test (effective for N-400 applications filed on or after October 20, 2025), replacing the 100-question test referenced in the V3 Bible.

Progression-based unlocking is managed through a Sectional Pool System that mirrors the Technical Manual V9 category schema (CAT_01 American Government Q1-72, CAT_02 American History Q73-118, CAT_03 Symbols & Holidays Q119-128) while keeping the House and Senate levels dynamic. The 128 questions are divided and released across levels as follows:

6.1 The House Floor: Initial Pool & The Correct-Answer Unlock Trigger

The game begins with a focused set of questions to ease the player into the “Freshman Representative” role.

- **Initial State:** The active pool is limited to Questions 1–16.
- **The Unlock Event (4-Correct-Answer Trigger):** Once the player has answered 4 questions correctly (from the initial 1-16 pool), the rest of CAT_01 unlocks.
- **The Expanded Pool:** This event appends Questions 17–72, completing CAT_01 (American Government) as the full active House pool.

Resolved: The Extremist Ambush / Technical Gauntlet still fires at 175 votes as its own story/combat beat, setting the Committee_Status flag (Friendly/Hostile Markup) that shapes the Committee mini-dungeon per Technical Manual V9. It is now fully decoupled from question-pool unlocking, which is governed solely by the 4-correct-answer trigger above.

6.2 Level-Based Sectional Rotation

As the player moves into deeper legislative “dungeons,” the thematic focus shifts to match the official test sections:

- **Committee Dungeons:** While technically part of the House, these mini-dungeons draw from the exact same active pool/deck as House Floor NPCs — not a separate reserved subset. Because Section 6.3's pop-and-discard logic already guarantees no question repeats once asked anywhere in the playthrough, sharing the deck between Floor and Committee prevents overlap automatically, with no extra partitioning logic required.
- **The Senate Wing:** Opens with Senate Pack 1 — Questions 73–118 (CAT_02: American History).
- **The Filibuster Gauntlet Trigger:** When the Gauntlet fires at 50 Senate votes, the active pool expands to include Questions 119–128 (CAT_03: Symbols & Holidays), bringing the full range through 128 into play for the remainder of the Senate.
- **The Oval Office:** The President is the only character who unlocks the Global Pool (1–128), treating the final encounter as a full “Naturalization Interview.”

6.3 The “No-Duplicate” Session Logic

To ensure variety and fairness, the engine uses specific “pop-and-discard” rules:

- **64-Question Limit:** Only 64 unique questions are selected for any single playthrough, meaning a player must play at least twice to see all 128 questions.
- **Second-Chance Swapping:** If the player gets a question wrong, the NPC executes a “Second-Chance” dialogue and pulls a new, unasked question from the active level pool so the player doesn't get stuck on the same hurdle.
- **The Scholar's Path:** Questions not encountered during the main floor sessions can be “unlocked” and added to the player's Notebook two ways. These entries are separate from the 64-question session cap — they're bonus, uncapped additions, not draws against the same pool.

- **Side-Quest Pool (~96 questions):** Obtainable through the 30 side quests (like “The Archivist’s Missing Ledger”). Not strictly one-for-one — some tourist-given side quests award a 5-question pack in one go rather than a single question.
- **Store-Exclusive Pool (30 questions):** A separate, dedicated set of 30 questions — weighted toward the multi-part “Name two/three...” questions from Section 6.5 — that can ONLY be obtained by purchasing them from the Rotunda Shop, never through side quests. Priced at a single flat INF cost per question, regardless of which one (exact figure part of the Tier 3 balance pass).
- **Ghost-Exclusive Pool (2 questions):** The final 2 of the 128 — the 22nd Amendment/two-term-limit fact (Washington) and the Emancipation Proclamation (Lincoln) — are obtainable only through the Ghosts of Washington & Lincoln encounters (Section 4.4), not through side quests or the Shop. This completes the full accounting: 96 (side-quest) + 30 (store-exclusive) + 2 (Ghost-exclusive) = 128.

Resolved: Unlocking a question this way adds the Q&A pair to the Notebook as study material only — it does not automatically award ‘answered’ credit or score. The player must still correctly answer that question in an actual encounter to earn score credit for it. The Notebook can be freely browsed at any time as prep/reference, EXCEPT while inside a live encounter, so it supports studying without functioning as an in-battle cheat sheet.

By the time the player reaches the Oval Office, the game has structurally moved them through the entire curriculum, from basic principles to complex systems and history, ensuring that the final showdown with the President is a culmination of everything unlocked along the way.

Full question-to-NPC/UI-mode routing within each sectional pool is still pending final art/placement pass (see Section 8).

6.4 Location-Dependent Answer Validation

Roughly 8 of the 128 questions have no single fixed answer (state capital, governor, senators, U.S. Representative, plus the fully national roles: President, Vice President, Speaker of the House, Chief Justice). These require a lookup-based validation path rather than simple string matching.

- **Save Creation Input:** At save creation, each player is prompted for their State (dropdown, to avoid typo/fuzzy-match issues on something that should be exact) and City (text entry), captured per individual save rather than as a single game-wide setting.
- **State-Level Lookup:** A built-in 50-state data table (capital, current governor, both current U.S. Senators) validates any state-capital/governor/senator question against the player’s saved State. This resolves those questions cleanly since state-level answers don’t vary within a state.
- **U.S. Representative — Best-Effort City Lookup:** Since congressional districts don’t map cleanly from state alone (some cities span multiple districts), the player’s saved City is checked against a city→district→Representative lookup table for a best-effort match.
- **Unresolvable Lookup Fallback:** If a player’s city isn’t found in the lookup table, or maps ambiguously to more than one district, the Representative question is treated the same way as a Second-Chance miss (Section 6.3): it’s swapped out for a different unasked question from the active pool, rather than blocking the encounter or guessing.
- **National-Role Questions:** President, Vice President, Speaker of the House, and Chief Justice use a separate small fixed-answer table (not location-dependent), following the same lookup pattern.

Maintenance note: all of these lookup tables (state governors/senators, city→Representative, and the national-role table) reflect real officeholders and will need periodic manual updates after elections/appointments — this is an ongoing content-maintenance task, not a one-time build step.

6.5 Multi-Part Answer Validation

Roughly a dozen questions ask for more than one item (“Name two rights in the Declaration of Independence,” “Name one branch of government,” “Describe one of the four constitutional amendments about who can vote”). These are handled differently depending on how the question is being presented:

- **Multiple-Choice Mode:** The question still displays its full wording (e.g., “Name two...”), but the number of correct selections actually required scales with the player's current Rapport toward that NPC, rather than a fixed count — the same rapport-modifies-difficulty pattern already established in Section 1.1, applied here specifically to multi-part questions. Higher rapport requires fewer correct picks; lower rapport requires more.
- **Open-Ended Mode:** Presented as a single text blank requiring only one correct answer at a time — never all parts at once, regardless of how many the question nominally asks for.
- **Repeat/Elimination Logic:** If the same multi-part question is drawn again later in the same playthrough (via the shared session pool described in Section 6.3), any answer(s) the player already gave correctly are excluded from the accepted list for that repeat instance, so the player must supply a fresh correct answer each time the question recurs.
- **Exception:** The Oval Office / President encounter never reuses these questions, so the elimination-tracking logic only applies to House, Senate, and Committee draws from the shared pool.

Cross-reference: many of these multi-part questions are among the 30 questions set aside for the Rotunda Shop's store-exclusive pool (Section 6.3) rather than the side-quest pool.

7. DC Map (Fully Optional Layer)

The DC map — monuments, message boards, press conferences, interns/staffers, and tourists — is entirely optional. It exists to let players earn Influence Points, collect Notebook Q&As and NPC intel, and learn the geography of the capital, without being required to finish the core campaign. The teacher already has a map layout planned for this area.

7.1 Tourist NPCs

Name	Personality
Mr. Pete Hollinger	Retired history teacher, overshares monument trivia, means well
Yuki Tanaka	Exchange student, genuinely curious, asks the player questions back
The Brennan Family	Field-trip parents, slightly overwhelmed, kids running ahead
Dolores Vance (no relation)	Genealogy researcher, ties everything back to 'her ancestors'
Cole Whitfield	College kid on a dare to visit every monument in one day, rushed energy
Ranger Ruth Ibarra	Actual former Park Service ranger, most reliable/knowledgeable of the bunch
Big Country Merck	Loud out-of-towner in a novelty hat, sharp once he stops posing for photos
Sister Agnes Boyle	Retired nun on a solo pilgrimage of 'every free thing in D.C.'
Deshawn Ottley	Street musician on break, treats questions like song trivia
The Kowalski Twins	Bickering siblings on a school trip; only answer if you settle their argument first
Marguerite Ffolliott	Eccentric amateur historian, loudly corrects tour guides, usually right
Benno the Vendor	Runs a hot dog cart, knows everyone, trades gossip for questions
Cadet Owusu	ROTC student on a solemn visit, formal and precise
Ilse Draeger	German tourist practicing her English, delighted by anything historical
“Roadmap” Higgins	Local eccentric who's memorized every DC bus route

The Ghosts of Washington and Lincoln (see Section 4.4) are the two hardest Notebook entries in the game and function as a hidden, two-stage secret layered on top of this tourist system.

Some of these tourists double as Scholar's Path side-quest givers (Section 6.3), awarding a 5-question Notebook pack in one go rather than a single question — which of the 15 tourists carry a pack quest is a placement detail pending final NPC assignment (see Section 8).

8. Open Items Before Build

- Art direction / style guide — pending upload from NotebookLM.
- **Asset plan (decided):** Tilesets/characters from LimeZu's Modern Interiors (interiors: House Floor, Committee, Senate, Rotunda) and Modern Exteriors (DC overworld) packs, both 16x16, with the built-in Character Generator used for NPC sprite variety instead of hand-drawing ~50 unique characters. DC landmarks (Washington Monument, Lincoln Memorial, Jefferson Memorial, U.S. Capitol, Supreme Court, Library of Congress) will be produced by recoloring/reskinning existing domed/columned building tiles from Modern Exteriors rather than commissioning custom art — revisit with a custom-art pass only if the recolors don't read clearly enough once placed on the map. UI/dialogue framing comes from LimeZu's companion “Modern User Interface - RPG asset pack [16x16]” (same art family, so visual style stays consistent across tiles/characters/UI), and NPC portrait busts will be built with the separately-acquired “Modern UI Portrait Generator” tool (by LegendarySwordsman2, a companion piece-by-piece portrait assembler for the Modern UI pack, available at 16x16/32x32/48x48).
- Finished map layouts (House, Senate, DC) — in hand, minor fixes pending on the teacher's end, including relabeling/removing the 'Rogue Nodes' pocket mistakenly shown on the House side of Image 2 (Rogue Senator Nodes are Senate-only; see Section 2.5's Backbench Reserve Pool for the House's equivalent mechanic).
- Placement of all named NPCs and tourists onto the actual maps once received.
- **RESOLVED:** Opposition President (Oval Office) path stays at its original 10-question/6-correct/30-second-timer structure — not updated to match the Ally President's 20/12/bonus structure. See Section 4.1.
- *RESOLVED:* Teacher coding-conference account approved.

9. Pre-Production Punch List

Section 8 tracks known content/asset gaps. This section captures everything else surfaced while reviewing the full design against itself — organized by how much they block coding, not by section order. Tier 1 items should be resolved before any engine work starts; Tiers 2-3 can be decided in parallel with early engine scaffolding; Tier 4 is content production that doesn't block code.

Tier 1 — Blocking (ALL RESOLVED)

- **1. Engine/stack choice.** *RESOLVED:* Phaser 3 + TypeScript + Vite, deployed as a static web build. Chosen for first-class tilemap support (matches the House/Senate/DC tile-based maps), Scene-per-level structure that mirrors the design doc's own section breakdown, and reliable browser support across platforms — PC, Mac, and Chromebook alike, since it's a standard webpage with no OS-specific dependencies. Confirmed: the game must run on PCs as well as Chromebooks, not Chromebook-exclusively; this stack already satisfies that without any architecture change.
- **2. Save/persistence model.** *RESOLVED (per Technical Manual V9):* a Save_Station terminal in the Rotunda exports a JSON blob (Vote_Counter, Influence_Points, Committee_Status, Passed_Flags, Notebook_Entries, etc.) to browser localStorage. No backend/server required.
- **3. Validation architecture for non-static answers.** *RESOLVED:* (a) current-officeholder/location-dependent questions (~8 of 128) use save-creation State/City input plus lookup tables (Section 6.4); (b) multi-part answers use rapport-scaled required-correct-count in MC mode and single-answer-at-a-time with repeat-elimination in open-ended mode (Section 6.5); (c) fuzzy-match parameters follow Technical Manual V9's Difficulty Delta table ($D \leq 5$ = 3-option MC, $5 \leq D \leq 15$ = open keyboard, $D \geq 40$ = 12-option confusion matrix or mumbled input).

Tier 2 — Core Logic Gaps (ALL RESOLVED)

- **4. Rogue Nodes ambiguity.** *RESOLVED:* Rogue Senator Nodes are Senate-only (Section 3.4). The House's ~40-vote safety valve is a separate, distinctly-named mechanic — the Backbench Reserve Pool (Section 2.5) — with uneven/randomized vote values per playthrough. Image 2's 'Rogue Nodes' label on the House side of the map is a labeling error to correct during the map-fix pass (see Section 8).

- **5. Path A (Overtime grind) vote math.** *RESOLVED (Technical Manual V9)*: the 10 Rogue Senator Nodes each secure 1 vote, together closing the 50-to-60 Cloture gap after a failed Filibuster Gauntlet.
- **6. Veto Override + session pool interaction.** *RESOLVED*: Override NPCs draw only from questions previously answered incorrectly or never asked, out of the player's original 64-question pool — never repeats of already-correct answers. Fallback: if that's exhausted, draw from the unused other-64 of the full 128-question bank. See Section 4.2.
- **7. Rotunda Shop / side-quest questions vs. the 64-cap.** *RESOLVED*: These entries are separate from the 64-question session cap (bonus, uncapped). They add the Q&A pair to the Notebook as study material only — no automatic 'answered' credit or score. The player must still correctly answer that question in a live encounter to earn score credit. The Notebook is freely browsable any time except during an active encounter.
- **8. Committee Dungeon question pool overlap.** *RESOLVED*: Committee Dungeons draw from the same shared active pool/deck as House Floor NPCs, not a separate reserved subset. Section 6.3's pop-and-discard logic already prevents repeats across the whole playthrough, so no extra partitioning logic is needed. See Section 6.2.

Tier 3 — Numeric / Balance Parameters (ALL RESOLVED)

- **9. Rapport score scale & thresholds.** *RESOLVED*: 0-100 scale, starts at 50, ± 15 per matching/mismatching dialogue choice, tiers at 0-33 Hostile / 34-66 Neutral / 67-100 Friendly. See Section 1.1.
- **10. Trait pool size & tell-to-rapport modifier mapping.** How large the randomized trait pool is, and how correctly reading a tell or scouted trait translates into rapport gain.
- **11. UI mode fuzzy-match tolerances.**
- **12. INF Economy.** *RESOLVED*: Earn rates (15/25/40 INF by Difficulty Delta tier) and Rotunda Shop pricing (25 INF flat per store-exclusive question, 30-250 INF for buff items) are calibrated so a thorough player can afford the entire 30-question store-exclusive pool AND other shop items in one playthrough (~1,400-1,800 INF earned vs. ~750 INF for all 30 questions). See Section 4.6.
- **13. Scoring formula.** *RESOLVED*: 10,000-point perfect-run target: 2,000 Base Clear + up to 800 Oval Office Accuracy + 2,000 Notebook Completion + up to 2,000 Day/Night Speed Bonus + up to 3,200 INF Efficiency. House/Senate feeds score only indirectly via INF, no separate point-track. See Section 4.5.
- **14. Whether House/Senate stages contribute to final score.** *RESOLVED*: Indirectly only, via INF earned there (Section 4.6) feeding the INF Efficiency Bonus (Section 4.5) — no separate parallel point-track.

Tier 4 — Content / Design Not Yet Spec'd (does not block engine work)

- **15. Committee Room maze mechanics.** *RESOLVED*: The Committee Room is a separate self-contained instance (not the literal Image 2 maze layout), entered once the player hits 175 votes. One large room, convince NPCs via shared-pool trivia + fetch-quest tasks, locked in until pass/fail. Both complexity and trivia difficulty scale with Committee_Status. Pass = +35 votes (one more encounter needed); Fail = +15 votes (several harder encounters needed). See Section 2.6.
- **16. Opposition President path alignment.** *RESOLVED*: stays at the original 10-question/6-correct/30-second-timer structure, not aligned to the Ally President's 20/12/bonus format. See Section 4.1.
- **17. Scholar's Path (65/20 Special Consideration) — CUT.** Removed from scope. The game is a classroom curriculum tool meant to teach the full 128-question set to 7th-grade students, most of whom are already citizens — an eligibility-based exemption mechanic from the real naturalization exam doesn't serve that goal and has been dropped entirely.
- **18-21. Art direction, map fixes, NPC/tourist placement, teacher account verification** (carried over from Section 8, Items 1-2-3-5).